

C204

Management Communication

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A plant manager with two decades on the floor sent a shift-change memo in plain English to a crew that includes several workers still learning English. The memo went out on the company's new messaging app at 6 a.m. Half the crew reported to the wrong line. Where did the communication break down?

- A. At encoding, because the manager lacks experience.
- B. At the channel, because messaging apps are too lean for scheduling.
- C. Nowhere; the manager sent the message, so the crew is responsible.
- D. At decoding, with no feedback step to catch the misunderstanding.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A regional director must tell a long-serving team lead that her role is being eliminated in a restructuring. The director is traveling next week and prefers email because it leaves a clear record, and HR has already approved the severance terms. Which channel best fits this message?

- A. A detailed email, because it creates a clear record.
- B. Always a formal letter, since job changes must never be discussed in person.
- C. A face-to-face or live video meeting, followed by written details.
- D. A company-wide announcement so everyone hears it at once.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager needs to tell 40 staff that the parking lot will be repaved on Saturday and that they should use the east lot that day. Which channel is the best fit?

- A. A video call, because richer channels are always better.
- B. No message; staff will see the signs.
- C. Individual face-to-face meetings with each employee.
- D. A short email or posted notice.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

Pitching a new safety program to the board in a paneled conference room, a vice president shows that similar programs at three peer firms cut injury claims by 30% and saved about \$1.2 million a year. She wears the company's standard blazer and speaks for exactly ten minutes. Which appeal is she mainly using?

- A. Logos.
- B. Pathos.
- C. Ethos, because her professional dress builds credibility.
- D. Ethos.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A nonprofit fundraiser wants donors to act on emotion and personal values rather than statistics. Which opening fits that goal?

- A. A list of the program's tax-deductibility rules.
- B. The director's 25 years of experience and awards.
- C. A short story of one family the program helped, with a photo.
- D. A chart of cost per meal served over five years.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A purchasing manager must reply to a loyal supplier whose bid lost to a lower-priced competitor. The supplier has worked with the company for nine years and sends a holiday gift each December. How should the reply be organized?

- A. Open by thanking them for the holiday gifts, then approve their bid.
- B. Indirect: a neutral buffer, the reasons, the decision, then a goodwill close.
- C. Reasons only, never stating the decision, to protect the relationship.
- D. Direct: state the rejection in the first sentence, then the reasons.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An HR director is writing to an applicant to offer her the job she interviewed for. How should the message be organized?

- A.** Direct: state the offer first, then details and next steps.
- B.** Always call instead; offers must never be written.
- C.** Start with salary negotiation limits, then the offer.
- D.** Indirect: open with a buffer, then give reasons before the offer.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

Two department heads dispute a shared budget line. After a two-hour session in the new downstairs meeting room, they design a plan that funds marketing's campaign in full and still gives IT the full server upgrade by shifting timing. Both are in their first year in the role. Which conflict style did they use?

- A.** Compromising.
- B.** Accommodating.
- C.** Collaborating.
- D.** Avoiding, because the fix was just a timing change.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager agrees to split a disputed training budget 50-50 between two teams even though each team needed the full amount. Which style is this?

- A.** Competing.
- B.** Compromising.
- C.** Collaborating.
- D.** Avoiding.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

An analyst who joined in March tells her supervisor, over coffee in the break room, that she feels buried by requests from three different project leads. Which supervisor response best shows active listening?

- A.** “So the requests from three leads are piling up and you’re not sure which to put first?”
- B.** “Just tell them all you’re busy.”
- C.** “Everyone new feels that way; you’ll get used to it.”
- D.** “I’ll reassign all your work today.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A product manager's launch memo to customers says the new app “passed all security testing.” It did pass every test that was run, but a known data-exposure issue was left out of the test plan. The memo uses the brand's new font and was approved by legal for grammar. Is the memo ethical?

- A.** Yes; legal approved it.
- B.** Yes; every sentence in it is literally true.
- C.** No; any memo that leaves out any test detail is unethical.
- D.** No; it is technically true but misleading by omission.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

In a quarterly review held in a glass-walled office, a director tells an employee “Your work is great” while frowning, arms crossed, and checking her phone. The employee has been with the firm for six years. What message is the employee most likely to take away?

- A.** That the review is confidential, given the glass walls.
- B.** That the director is not actually satisfied.
- C.** That the work is great, because that is what was said.
- D.** Nothing; mixed messages always cancel out completely.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A plant manager ~~with two decades on the floor~~ sent a shift-change memo in plain English to a crew that includes several workers still learning English. The memo went out ~~on the company's new messaging app at 6 a.m.~~ Half the crew reported to the wrong line. Where did the communication break down?

Target word: which step failed **Decides:** The receivers could not decode the message as intended and no feedback loop confirmed it.

A	Adjacent category	Encoding was fine for a fluent reader; the failure was on the receiving side.
B	Camouflage	Answers the new-app detail; routine schedule facts suit a lean channel if receivers can decode them.
C	Dropped element	Drops decoding and feedback; sending is not the same as communicating.
D	Correct	Language was noise at the receiver's end, and nobody checked understanding before the shift.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A regional director must tell a long-serving team lead that her role is being eliminated in a restructuring. ~~The director is traveling next week and prefers email because it leaves a clear record, and HR has already approved the severance terms.~~ Which channel best fits this message?

Target word: best channel **Decides:** The message is personal, emotional, and likely to raise questions.

A	Camouflage	Answers the director's preference; a record does not make a lean channel right for bad personal news.
B	Absolute language	No such rule; the in-person talk comes first and documentation follows.
C	Correct	Sensitive, emotional news needs a rich channel with immediate feedback; the record can follow.
D	Adjacent category	Group announcements suit general restructuring news, not an individual's job loss.

3. Answer D Concept 2 · transfer

A manager needs to tell 40 staff that the parking lot will be repaved on Saturday and that they should use the east lot that day. Which channel is the best fit?

Target word: channel for a routine message **Decides:** The message is simple, factual, and not sensitive.

A	Absolute language	Richness should match the message; too rich for simple facts is inefficient.
B	Dropped element	Drops the communication entirely for information staff need in advance.
C	Inverted operation	Uses the rich channel meant for sensitive messages on routine news; wastes time.
D	Correct	Routine, unambiguous facts suit a lean, fast, documented channel.

4. Answer A Concept 3

Pitching a new safety program to the board in a paneled conference room, a vice president shows that similar programs at three peer firms cut injury claims by 30% and saved about \$1.2 million a year. ~~She wears the company's standard blazer and speaks for exactly ten minutes.~~ Which appeal is she mainly using?

Target word: type of appeal **Decides:** Her case rests on comparative data and savings.

A	Correct	Evidence and cost reasoning are appeals to logic.
B	Confusion set	Pathos targets feelings; she argues with numbers.
C	Camouflage	Answers the blazer detail; dress is not what carries her argument.
D	Confusion set	Ethos rests on the speaker's credibility, not on the data she cites.

5. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

A nonprofit fundraiser wants donors to act on emotion and personal values rather than statistics. Which opening fits that goal?

Target word: choose the tactic for pathos **Decides:** Pathos works through emotion and values.

A	Adjacent category	Useful information, but a factual appeal, not an emotional one.
B	Confusion set	Credentials build ethos.
C	Correct	A personal story engages feelings and values: pathos.
D	Confusion set	Data and efficiency are logos.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A purchasing manager must reply to a loyal supplier whose bid lost to a lower-priced competitor. The supplier has worked with the company for nine years ~~and sends a holiday gift each December.~~ How should the reply be organized?

Target word: message structure for bad news **Decides:** The reader will not welcome the main point.

A	Camouflage	Answers the gift detail and reverses the actual decision.
B	Correct	Bad news to a valued reader goes indirect so the reasons prepare them for the decision.
C	Dropped element	Drops the main point; the reader must still learn the outcome clearly.
D	Inverted operation	Direct order is for good or routine news and receptive readers.

7. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

An HR director is writing to an applicant to offer her the job she interviewed for. How should the message be organized?

Target word: structure for good news **Decides:** The reader will welcome the main point.

A	Correct	Good news goes first so the reader gets it immediately.
B	Absolute language	Offers are routinely written; the question is order, not channel.
C	Adjacent category	Details come after the main point, not before it.
D	Inverted operation	Buffers are for bad news; they delay welcome news for no reason.

8. Answer C Concept 5

Two department heads dispute a shared budget line. After a ~~two-hour session in the new downstairs meeting room~~, they design a plan that funds marketing's campaign in full and still gives IT the full server upgrade by shifting timing. ~~Both are in their first year in the role.~~ Which conflict style did they use?

Target word: name the style **Decides:** Both sides got their full needs met through a creative solution.

A	Confusion set	Compromise means each side gives something up; here neither did.
B	Confusion set	Accommodating means one side yields; both got what they needed.
C	Correct	High assertiveness and cooperation produce a win-win where neither gives up core goals.
D	Adjacent category	Avoiding sidesteps the conflict; they confronted and solved it.

9. Answer B Concept 5 • transfer

A manager agrees to split a disputed training budget 50-50 between two teams even though each team needed the full amount. Which style is this?

Target word: name the style from the outcome **Decides:** Each side gave up part of what it needed.

A	Confusion set	Competing means one side wins at the other's expense.
B	Correct	Splitting the difference means moderate gains and moderate losses for both.
C	Inverted operation	Collaboration meets both sides' full needs; this split meets neither's.
D	Confusion set	The manager dealt with the issue rather than dodging it.

10. Answer A Concept 6

An analyst ~~who joined in March~~ tells her supervisor, ~~over coffee in the break room~~, that she feels buried by requests from three different project leads. Which supervisor response best shows active listening?

Target word: active-listening response **Decides:** Active listening confirms understanding before advising.

A	Correct	Paraphrases content and feeling and invites her to confirm or correct.
B	Adjacent category	Advice, not listening; it skips confirming what the problem is.
C	Camouflage	Reacts to her start date and dismisses the concern instead of understanding it.
D	Absolute language	An all-or-nothing fix before understanding the problem.

11. Answer D Concept 7

A product manager's launch memo to customers says the new app "passed all security testing." It did pass every test that was run, but a known data-exposure issue was left out of the test plan. ~~The memo uses the brand's new font and was approved by legal for grammar.~~ Is the memo ethical?

Target word: ethical or not **Decides:** A literally true claim leaves customers with a false impression.

A	Camouflage	A grammar review does not address honesty.
B	Dropped element	Drops the impression the message creates; literal truth is not enough.
C	Absolute language	Omitting minor detail is normal; omitting a material known risk is the problem.
D	Correct	Ethics requires that the audience not be misled; omitting the known issue does that.

12. Answer B Concept 8

In a quarterly review ~~held in a glass-walled office~~, a director tells an employee “Your work is great” while frowning, arms crossed, and checking her phone. ~~The employee has been with the firm for six years.~~ What message is the employee most likely to take away?

Target word: what the receiver believes **Decides:** Words and nonverbal cues conflict.

A	Camouflage	The room does not decide how the message is read.
B	Correct	When words and body language conflict, receivers usually trust the nonverbal cues.
C	Inverted operation	Reverses which signal dominates in a mixed message.
D	Absolute language	Mixed messages do not cancel; the nonverbal side usually wins.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The communication process and noise	A message is encoded, sent through a channel, decoded, and confirmed by feedback; noise is anything at any step that distorts meaning.	Thinking a message was communicated because it was sent.	The sender says it was sent, but the receiver acted on a different meaning.
2	Channel richness	Match the channel to the message: complex, sensitive, or ambiguous messages need rich channels (face to face, video); routine facts suit lean channels (email, memo).	Using the fastest or most documented channel for every message.	Emotion, ambiguity, or bad personal news in the message.
3	Persuasive appeals: ethos, pathos, logos	Ethos persuades through the speaker's credibility, pathos through the audience's emotions and values, logos through evidence and reasoning.	Calling any use of numbers ethos or any story logos.	What the persuader leans on: who they are, how it feels, or what the data shows.
4	Direct vs. indirect message structure	Lead with the main point for routine or good news and receptive audiences; use a buffer and reasons before bad news or with resistant audiences.	Opening every message with the bottom line, including a rejection.	Whether the reader will welcome or resist the main point.
5	Conflict-handling styles	Collaborating is high assertiveness and high cooperation (win-win); competing is high/low; accommodating is low/high; avoiding is low/low; compromising is in the middle (each gives up some).	Treating compromise as the win-win style.	Whether both sides fully get their core needs met or each gives something up.
6	Active listening	Active listening means attending, paraphrasing, and asking clarifying questions to confirm understanding before responding or advising.	Jumping to solutions or advice as a form of listening.	A response that restates the speaker's meaning and feelings.
7	Ethical communication	Ethical messages are truthful and complete enough that the audience is not misled; a technically true statement that leaves a false impression is still deceptive.	Believing a message is ethical as long as every sentence is literally true.	Selective facts or omitted context that change what the audience will conclude.
8	Nonverbal cues and mixed messages	When words and nonverbal cues conflict, receivers tend to believe the nonverbal cues.	Assuming the spoken words carry the message.	Positive words paired with contradicting tone, posture, or facial expression.

Course scope (public description): This course prepares students for the communication challenges in organizations. Topics examined include theories and strategies of communication, persuasion, conflict management, and ethics that enhance communication to various audiences.